

WAR ON HEALTH

A turf war is brewing in the state's healthcare sector and medics are now shunning government jobs. With countless posts lying vacant in state medical colleges, public health is in a mess.

■ **By Farzand Ahmed**

It's hard to retain, let alone recruit, a doctor in Uttar Pradesh these days. That's the bitter lesson the authorities of the prestigious Chhatrapati Sahuji Maharaj Medical University (CSMMU), formerly, King George's Medical College, in Lucknow, learnt when they advertised for seven cardiology posts recently. Only four interviewees turned up and out of the selected two, only one joined. And this was not a stand-alone incident. Out of the six government medical colleges in the state, five are running with ad-hoc principals and this shortage of teachers may even result in the de-recognition of the medical colleges.

At a time when India's healthcare sector is witnessing an unprecedented boom, horror stories in health are ricocheting in the country's biggest state. As always the victim is the public and the culprit is politics. With medical practitioners, the police and the bureaucracy locking horns, health is a war-zone. If in the last round, the latter slapped charges of immoral private practice on "greedy doctors", medics have hit back by shunning jobs in medical colleges and state health services.

Check out the statistics. Over 80 per cent posts of super-specialists in state hospitals and medical colleges are lying vacant. Even state health minister Anant Kumar Mishra admitted recently that only 197 medics had responded to the 900 posts advertised by the state Public Service Commission. The prestigious CSMMU has no specialists in nephrology, transfusion, organ transplant and community dentistry, while the numbers are dwindling in radio diagnosis and cardio-thoracic vascular surgery. Out of the 28 posts advertised at the dental college, just 12 medics applied and only

four took up the jobs. The Lucknow Civil Hospital has only two anesthetists while six posts remain unfilled. This story repeats itself across the state.

One of the pet peeves among the medical fraternity is low government salary. "We get salaries that are lower than those of teachers in colleges," says Dr Naim Ahmad, general secretary of the CSMMU Teachers' Association (CTA). "We do not get conveyance, periodical allowances, medical reimbursements or financial assistance to attend seminars that doctors in premier institutes get," he adds. Along with fancy buildings, well-appointed surroundings and good equipment, a professor in a private medical college gets around Rs 75,000. In contrast, professors at the medical university and government colleges get between Rs 35,000-40,000, says Prof. R.K. Saran, one of the vice-presidents of CTA.

Apart from market forces, political pulls and pressure at work also make the medicos seethe with anger. Chief Minister Mayawati holds the portfolio of medical education and the "high-handed attitude" of her favourite bu-



ON THE BRINK: It is the poor who suffer

reaucrats toward the medical community has created much tension. The issue of "private practice" by government doctors has been a sore point. Last year, the state high court came down heavily on doctors and directed the government to depute intelligence officials to list the errants. Though the doctors tried to sway Mayawati, the government stood firm. Ever since, there has been a flood of applications for voluntary retirements, says Dr Nasim Jamal, professor of radiology with CSMMU.

Matters came to a head last month, when the police conducted raids at the residences of well-known CSMMU professors, without taking the university into confidence. CTA members gheraoed the vice-chancellor, suspended medical services and declared that they would not treat VIPs. Moreover, 31 specialists applied for voluntary retirement. Fearing a revolt by doctors, the government stopped the raids and assured them that their demands for better pay would be considered, says Dr Ahmad.

The association wants the pay

WHERE'S THE DOCTOR?

Healthcare hits rock bottom as medicos leave the state's best hospital for the private sector

Speciality	Total seats	Vacancies
General	396	147
Dental	68	29
Cardio thoracic	4	3
Nephrology	2	2
Radio diagnosis	7	5
Human transfusion	3	3
Human organ transplant	3	3
ENT	5	2
Community dentistry	5	5
Plastic surgery	6	3
Gastro surgery	8	5
Medicine	20	12